tanks to publicly air their views, including whenever they wish to be critical of the Government of India, without offering the same privilege or access to Indian think-tanks or experts who visit China.

The last, eighth, agency is the Central Foreign Affairs Commission (*Zhongyang Waishi Gongzuo Weiyuanhui* or CFAC), nominally headed by Xi Jinping and run by Politburo Member Yang Jiechi from a Secretariat that is led by a Vice Minister level official from the Foreign Ministry. Under Xi Jinping, the CFAC has become the main coordinating body that reconciles the conflicting interests of the various stakeholders in a negotiation, in order to arrive at a consensus on the negotiating position and posture.

Hence, the Chinese foreign policy actors are like the proverbial octopus—eight tentacles controlled by a central nerve centre. The eight tentacles are the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the People's Liberation Army (PLA), the Ministry of State Security (MSS), the United Front Work Department (UFWD), the International Department of the Communist Party (ILD), the State Council Information Office (SCIO), the Chinese think-tanks and, finally, the Central Foreign Affairs Commission (CFAC) of the Central Committee of the Communist Party; the nerve centre or controller is General Secretary Xi Jinping who has taken personal charge of many of the eight tentacles of this octopus. No General Secretary has made more speeches on foreign policy than Xi Jinping. New offices and coordinating bodies have been set up by him; 'Xi Jinping Thought on Socialist Diplomacy with Chinese Characteristics for a New Era' has been unveiled; and the Xi Jinping Thought on Diplomacy Research Centre has been set up under the aegis of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in July 2020. [22] According to the Chinese Foreign Minister, Wang Yi, General Secretary Xi Jinping has made his assessment of the trajectory of the international situation and